

Transcript of Presidential Meeting in the Cabinet Room of the White House

Topic: Supplemental appropriations for the National Aeronautics and Space
Administration (NASA)

21 November 1962¹

Present at the meeting:

President John F. Kennedy

James Webb, NASA Administrator

Dr. Jerome Wiesner, Special Assistant to the President for Science and Technology

Edward Welsh, Executive Secretary, National Aeronautics and Space Council

David E. Bell, Director, Bureau of the Budget

Dr. Hugh Dryden, Deputy Administrator, NASA

Dr. Robert Seamans, Associate Administrator, NASA

Dr. Brainerd Holmes, Associate Administrator for Manned Space Flight, NASA

Elmer Staats, Deputy Director, Bureau of the Budget

Willis H. Shapley, Deputy Division Chief, Military Division, Bureau of the Budget

(Vice President Lyndon Johnson was scheduled to attend but did not.)

[Muffled laughter and conversations.]

President Kennedy: What I understand, it is a question of whether we need four hundred million dollars more to maintain our present schedule, is that correct?

James Webb: Well, it's very hard to say what our present schedule is. I think the easiest way to...to understand what has happened is to say that we started out after you made the decision in May to come forward with a driving program. We used the best information we had and we settled on late '67 or early '68 as the landing date. We wanted to have some leeway within the decade. Now this was a target date—we recognized we might have some slippage. We had some financial estimates at that time, which have proved to be too small, that the... the increased cost estimated by the contractor is partly because each of them has added to the cost that he submitted on his contract proposals to us. And second, we have added requirements to each of these vehicles.

¹ John F. Kennedy Library President's Office files.
Presidential recordings collection tape #63.

There are no excisions.

For additional information, please see recording log #63.

Transcript prepared by Dwayne A. Day. Additional assistance provided by Glen Swanson, John M. Logsdon, Stephen Garber, and Robert Seamans.

James Webb: We know a great deal more.

Unknown speaker: I think this is a much sounder basis. I would be surprised if the cost went up by three....

Robert Seamans: I would be surprised if it went up more than sixty percent.

Unknown speaker: But that's still a lot of money!

James Webb: Well, let me make a statement on that I have made to the Budget Director. You remember when I first talked to you about this program, the first statement I made to Congress was that the lunar program would cost between twenty and forty billion dollars. Now I am able to say right now it's going to be under the twenty billion, under the lower limit that we used. The question is how rapidly you spend the money and...and how efficiently you manage this so as to get the most possible for the money. This can be speeded up at the expense of...of certain things which I outlined in this letter to you. It can be slowed up if, a year from now, we find that we don't have to proceed at this basis. But this is a good, sound, solid program that would keep all of the governmental agencies and the contractors and the rest moving ahead. But we're prepared to move if you really want to put it on a crash basis.

President Kennedy: Do you put.... Do you put this program.... Do you think this program is the top-priority program of the Agency?

James Webb: No, sir, I do not. I think it is *one* of the top-priority programs, but I think it's very important to recognize here...and that you have found what you could do with a rocket as you could find how you could get out beyond the Earth's atmosphere and into space and make measurements. Several scientific disciplines that are the very powerful and begin to converge on this area.

President Kennedy: Jim, I think it is the top priority. I think we ought to have that very clear. Some of these other programs can slip six months, or nine months, and nothing strategic is gonna happen, it's gonna.... But this is important for political reasons, international political reasons. This is, whether we like it or not, in a sense a race. If we get second to the Moon, it's nice, but it's like being second any time. So that if we're second by six months, because we didn't give it the kind of priority, then of course that would be very serious. So I think we have to take the view that this is the top priority with us.

James Webb: But the environment of space is where you are going to operate the Apollo and where you are going to do the landing.

President Kennedy: Look, I know all these other things and the satellite and the communications and weather and all, they're all desirable, but they can wait.

James Webb: I'm not putting those.... I am talking now about the scientific program to understand the space environment within which you got to fly Apollo and make a landing on the Moon.

President Kennedy: Wait a minute—is that saying that the lunar program to land the man on the Moon is the top priority of the Agency, is it?

Unknown speaker: And the science that goes with it....

Robert Seamans: Well, yes, if you add that, the science that is necessary....

President Kennedy: The science.... Going to the Moon is the top-priority project. Now, there are a lot of related scientific information and developments that will come from that which are important. But the whole thrust of the Agency, in my opinion, is the lunar program. The rest of it can wait six or nine months.

James Webb: The trouble...Jerry is holding up his hand.... Let me say one thing, then maybe you want to [unknown] the thing that troubles me here about making such a flat statement as that is, number one, there are real unknowns as to whether man can live under the weightless condition and you'll ever make the lunar landing. This is one kind of political vulnerability I'd like to avoid such a flat commitment to. If you say you failed on your number-one priority, this is something to think about. Now, the second point is that as we can go out and make measurements in space by being physically able to get there, the scientific work feeds the technology and the engineers begin to make better spacecraft. That gives you better instruments and a better chance to go out to learn more. Now right all through our universities some of the brilliant able scientists are recognizing this and beginning to get into this area and you are generating here on a national basis an intellectual effort of the highest order of magnitude that I've seen develop in this country in the years I've been fooling around with national policy. Now, to them, there is a real question. The people that are going to furnish the brainwork, the real brainwork, on which the future space power of this nation for twenty-five or a hundred years are going to be made, have got some doubts about it and....

President Kennedy: Doubts about what, with this program?

James Webb: As to whether the actual landing on the Moon is what you call the highest priority.

President Kennedy: What do they think is the highest priority?

James Webb: They think the highest priority is to understand the environment and...and the areas of the laws of nature that operate out there as they apply backwards into space. You can say it this way. I think Jerry ought to talk on this rather than me, but the scientists in the nuclear field have penetrated right into the most minute areas of the nucleus and the subparticles of the nucleus. Now here, out in the universe, you've got the same general kind of a structure, but you can do it on a massive universal scale.

President Kennedy: I agree that we're interested in this, but we can wait six months on all of it.

James Webb: But you have to use that information to....

President Kennedy: Yeah, but only as that information directly applies to the program. Jim, I think we've gotta have that....

[Unintelligible.]

Jerome Wiesner: [Unintelligible—"If you got enough time?"] Mr. President, I don't think Jim understands some of the scientific problems that are associated with landing on the Moon and this is what Dave Bell was trying to say and what I'm trying to say. We don't know a damn thing about the surface of the Moon. And we're making the wildest guesses about how we're going to land on the Moon and we could get a terrible disaster from putting something down on the surface of the Moon that's very different than we think it is. And the scientific programs that find us that information have to have the highest priority. But they are associated with the lunar program. The scientific programs that aren't associated with the lunar program can have any priority we please to give 'em.

Unknown speaker: That's consistent with what the President was saying.

Robert Seamans: Yeah. Could I just say that I agree with what you say, Jerry, that we must gather a wide variety of scientific data in order to carry out the lunar mission. For example, we must know what conditions we'll find on the lunar surface. That's the reason that we are proceeding with Centaur in order to get the Surveyor unmanned spacecraft to the Moon in time that it could affect the design of the Apollo.

President Kennedy: The other thing is I would certainly not favor spending six or seven billion dollars to find out about space no matter how on the schedule we're doing. I would spread it out over a five- or ten-year period. But we can spend it on.... Why are we spending seven million dollars on getting fresh water from saltwater, when we're spending seven billion dollars to find out about space? Obviously, you wouldn't put it on that priority except for the defense implications. And the second point is the fact that the Soviet Union has made this a test of the system. So that's why we're doing it. So I think we've got to take the view that this is the key program. The rest of this...we can find out all about

it, but there's a lot of things we can find out about; we need to find out about cancer and everything else.

James Webb: But you see, when you talk about this, it's very hard to draw a line between what....

President Kennedy: Everything that we do ought to really be tied into getting onto the Moon ahead of the Russians.

James Webb: Why can't it be tied to preeminence in space, which are your own....

President Kennedy: Because, by God, we keep, we've been telling everybody we're preeminent in space for five years and nobody believes it because they have the booster and the satellite. We know all about the number of satellites we put up, two or three times the number of the Soviet Union...we're ahead scientifically. It's like that instrument you got up at Stanford which is costing us a hundred and twenty-five million dollars and everybody tells me that we're the number one in the world. And what is it? I can't think what it is.

Interruption from multiple unknown speakers: The linear accelerator.

President Kennedy: I'm sorry, that's wonderful, but nobody knows anything about it!

James Webb: Let me say it slightly different. The advanced Saturn is eighty-five times as powerful as the Atlas. Now we are building a tremendous giant rocket with an index number of eighty-five if you give me Atlas one. Now, the Russians have had a booster that'll lift fourteen thousand pounds into orbit. They've been very efficient and capable in it. The kinds of things I'm talking about that give you preeminence in space are what permits you to make either that Russian booster or the advanced Saturn better than any other. A range of progress possible it is so much different [unknown].

President Kennedy: The only.... We're not going to settle the four hundred million this morning. I want to take a look closely at what Dave Bell.... But I do think we ought get it, you know, really clear that the policy ought to be that this is *the* top-priority program of the Agency, and one of the two things, except for defense, the top priority of the United States government. I think that that is the position we ought to take. Now, this may not change anything about that schedule, but at least we ought to be clear, otherwise we shouldn't be spending this kind of money because I'm not that interested in space. I think it's good; I think we ought to know about it; we're ready to spend reasonable amounts of money. But we're talking about these *fantastic* expenditures which wreck our budget and all these other domestic programs and the only justification for it, in my opinion, to do it in this time or fashion, is because we hope to beat them and demonstrate that starting behind, as we did by a couple years, by God, we passed them.

James Webb: I'd like to have more time to talk about that because there is a wide public sentiment coming along in this country for preeminence in space.

President Kennedy: If you're trying to prove preeminence, this is the way to prove your preeminence.

James Webb: It's not if you've got an advanced Saturn rocket...[unintelligible].

President Kennedy: We do have to talk about this. Because I think if this affects in any way our sort of allocation of resources and all the rest, then it is a substantive question and I think we've got to get it clarified. I'd like to have you tell me in a brief...you write me a letter, your views. I'm not sure that we're far apart. I think all these programs which contribute to the lunar program are...come within, or contribute significantly or really in a sense...let's put it this way, are *essential*, put it that way...*are essential* to the success of the lunar program, are justified. Those that are not essential to the lunar program, that help contribute over a broad spectrum to our preeminence in space, are secondary. That's my feeling.

James Webb: All right, then let me say this: if I go out and say that this is the number-one priority and that everything else must give way to it, I'm going to lose an important element of support for your program and for your administration.

President Kennedy [interrupting]: By who? Who? What people? Who?

James Webb: By a large number of people.

President Kennedy: Who? Who?

James Webb: Well, particularly the brainy people in industry and in the universities who are looking at a solid base.

President Kennedy: But they're not going to pay the kind of money to get that position that we are [who we are] spending it. I say the only reason you can justify spending this tremendous...why spend five or six billion dollars a year when all these other programs are starving to death?

James Webb: Because in Berlin you spent six billion a year adding to your military budget because the Russians acted the way they did. And I have some feeling that you might not have been as successful on Cuba if we hadn't flown John Glenn and demonstrated we had a real overall technical capability here.

President Kennedy: We agree. That's why we wanna put this program.... That's the dramatic evidence that we're preeminent in space.

James Webb: But we didn't put him on the Moon...[unintelligible].

Unknown speakers: [Unintelligible]...we did what we needed to do.

David Bell: I think, Mr. President, that you're not as far apart as this sounds. Because the budget that they have submitted, 464....

President Kennedy: I know we're not far apart, I'm sure, and the budget we may not be apart at all. But I do think at least we're in words somewhat apart. And I'd like to get those words just the same.

James Webb: It's, it's perfectly fine. I think....

President Kennedy: How about you writing me and telling me how you assign these priorities. And perhaps I could write you my own....

James Webb: But I do think it...it certainly doesn't hurt us to have this *Time* article that shows we are really going ahead with the program. I don't think that hurts the Agency; I don't think it hurts at all. You have tried several times to say that's number one. But I also think that as Administrator, I've got to take a little broader view of all the budgets here including those that are [unintelligible] appropriation in the Congress. I don't think we've got to use precisely the same word.

Robert Seamans: Could I state my view on this? I believe that we proceeded on Mercury, and we're now proceeding on Gemini and Apollo as the number-one program in NASA. It has a DX priority. Nothing else has a DX priority.

James Webb: And recommended four-point-seven billion funds for it for 1962! That's a....

Robert Seamans: At the same time, when you say something has a top priority, in my view it doesn't mean that you completely emasculate everything else if you run into budget problems on the Apollo and the Gemini. Because you could very rapidly completely eliminate you[r] meteorological program, your communications program, and so on. If you took that to too great of an extreme....

James Webb: And the advanced technology on which military power is going to be based.

Hugh Dryden: Mr. President, I think this is the issue. Suppose Apollo has an overrun of five hundred million dollars, to reprogram five hundred million dollars for the rest of the space program would just throw the whole thing all away. And I think this is the worry in Jim's mind about top priority.

President Kennedy: Listen, I think in the letter you ought to mention how the other programs which the Agency is carrying out tie into the lunar program, and what their connection is, and how essential they are to the target dates we're talking about, and if they are only indirectly related, what their contribution is to the general and specific things [unknown—possibly “we’re doing”] in space. Thank you very much.

[Kennedy gets up to leave the room.]

James Webb: Thank you, Mr. President.

Unknown speaker: Thank you.

[Unintelligible as speakers shuffle paper and President and possibly some others get up to leave the room.]

James Webb: Dave, is there anything we can say about where we stand.... Now you see, one of the things that [Hogenfifer? unknown] said about [unknown] the cause of the delay and the lunar orbit [unknown] the sensitive nature of the budget decision. We have not wanted, at the top, to be too *firm* about the schedule. Brainerd had to be firm and drive people and say, “Get off; we got to beat these dates, you see.” The fact that Congress was so ready to put a pass on the budget—all of these things have sort of created the kind of situation...what are our next moves? Of course I'll write this letter...but that won't settle it. I mean, this will be a burning argument for the next twenty years in this country about what are the priorities in space.

David Bell: The action questions that are before the President revolve around the '64 Budget including the question of the '63 supplemental agreement.

James Webb: I thought your letter was a splendid presentation.

David Bell: Now this has to be settled in the next two weeks. You know the whole '64 budget is in the final stages, and this supplemental in the next couple weeks—it is all coming into focus, so that this isn't something that is gonna lag on.

Unknown speaker: Right.

James Webb: Then we don't need to do anything with respect to our contractors or Centers for that that period of time, other than what we've done, do we?

Unknown speaker: No.

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[Kennedy gets up to leave the room.]

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